

Rania Ahmed

Apparel Developer Specialized

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Summary

Innovate apparel development and create new ideas that improve performance, quality and lead apparel development industry standards. Collaborate with business counterparts to drive operation process improvements to maximize development efficiencies and optimize growth potential and profitability.

Education

University of Oregon

Bachelor of Arts: Sociology

1996, Eugene, Oregon, USA

Experience

Apparel Developer Specialized

On-Site

Raya Apparel Group

Jan 2014 - Current

- Established new fast track business model for junior (JR) fashion across all product categories.
- Collaborated with cross-functional leadership to identify new sourcing needs and onboard new suppliers, ensuring adherence to Nordstrom product requirements.
- Developed tools to accelerate the development process while maintaining critical product testing and Nordstrom quality standards.
- Led weekly status meetings with upper management to review progress, track projects, and address potential concerns for successful project delivery.
- Supported technical woven development projects, including outerwear, denim, and soft dressing, guiding the team on new approaches to costing tools, streamlining meetings, and optimizing existing systems.
- Addressed vendor issues promptly to steer projects back on course, managing sourcing across United States, China, India, Nicaragua, and Colombia.

Manager Development Apparel

On-Site

Spinneys Egypt (Apparel Division)

Jan 2006 - Jan 2014

- Managed apparel development for diverse categories including snowboarding outerwear, base layers, women's swim, board shorts, denim, woven shirts, t-shirts, sweatshirts, technical performance basketball, and women's fashion knits.
- Built comprehensive tech packs and maintained daily communication with factories to ensure accurate execution of technical product assortments.
- Collaborated with design and marketing to provide upfront costing analysis in the design phase, reducing labor rates by 10% and increasing profit.
- Updated workmanship sketches, material call outs, and technical images in Illustrator format on tech packs for factory communication.
- Conducted factory workshops to improve process efficiency and reduce development time, enhancing responsiveness to promotional needs.
- Innovated and standardized operational processes for category growth, particularly for promotional business unit expansion.
- Worked with athletes on wear testing trials to gather feedback for product improvements.
- Coordinated and managed fit sessions with cross-functional teams to review styles and execute necessary adjustments.
- Directly engaged with suppliers and manufacturers to gain in-depth technical knowledge, applying insights to product developments.
- Led costing, improvements, and technical quality standards to ensure all end results were achieved.
- Provided development input for calendar setup of a new business unit, collaborating with marketing, design, materials, planning, costing, quality, and sourcing to ensure accurate timelines and successful buy-ready dates.
- Selected for multiple high-profile, short-timeline projects with limited guidance, delivering excellent results for collections including Olympics, All Star, and Jeremy Scott.

- Conducted weekly cross-functional meetings to foster better communication and share updates relevant to the wider team.
- Mentored new team members by implementing a new business unit manual and teaching development tasks.
- Tested products at multiple development stages, communicating results and potential risks with marketing to suggest risk mitigation strategies for production.
- Managed sourcing and worked in regions including Thailand, China, Indonesia, Turkey, US, India, Bangladesh, and Nicaragua.

Product Developer Production Assistant

On-Site

El-Araby Group

Jan 2003 - Jan 2005

- Planned and purchased blanks and finished goods for private label needs.
- Updated and tracked Open-to-Buy (OTB) reporting to ensure all product needs were met for store sales requirements.
- Worked with sourcing agents to develop new board shorts, prints, fleece, polo's, t-shirts, woven shirts, and woven shorts.
- Sent out tech packs including specs, color standards, material needs, graphics, and all product requirements.
- Managed fit sessions from first prototype to extended size sets, documenting final graded specs for factory and production.
- Conducted all necessary quality testing in development, including color tests, wash testing, and wear testing.
- Collaborated with screen-printing and embroidery technicians to ensure blank products passed embellishment testing.
- Set up a concept surf shop on Maui, buying from selected surf brands covering junior men's, women's, accessories, surfboards, and skateboards.
- Selected stock blank suppliers to produce private label programs, ensuring margin targets were met.
- Managed SKU volume of approximately 700 with an estimated annual volume of \$25 million.

Consultant

On-Site

Fashion Edge Consulting

Jan 2003 - Jan 2003

- Collaborated with a local Roxy store owner to improve assortment and establish an Open-to-Buy (OTB) program.
- Reviewed floor setup and enhanced merchandising strategies.
- Implemented an immediate buy strategy to address stock deficiencies and reduce assortment on slow-selling items to improve turn time.

Men's Surf Buyer and Product Developer

On-Site

Activewear Egypt

Jan 1999 - Jan 2003

- Tracked and maintained stock-to-sales, gross margin reporting, and location sales for 7 retail stores, consistently exceeding sales targets each month.
- Managed slow-selling merchandise through sell-backs, discounts, merchandise transfers, and exit strategies while maintaining margin requirements.
- Merchandised stores weekly through regular store visits to optimize sales potential.
- Sourced products from vendors like Quiksilver, Billabong, Hurley, Volcom, Ripcurl, Lost, Split, and local surf brands to maintain a fresh and in-demand assortment.
- Developed monthly promotions in partnership with brands to incentivize customers and drive sales of selected brands.
- Planned Open-to-Buy (OTB) seasonally and managed chase orders to respond to market demands.
- Attended action sports trade shows to identify new trends and build vendor relationships.
- Managed SKU volume of approximately 700 with an estimated annual volume of \$1.5 million.
- Developed private label board shorts, cargo shorts, and aloha shirts with sourcing agents.
- Collaborated with surfers to develop ultimate board shorts, including testing materials, seam placements, fit, thread, and stitches.
- Researched marketplace trends to identify business growth opportunities.
- Worked closely with store managers to monitor stock-to-sales by region and execute quick transfers to maximize merchandising potentials.

Buyer

On-Site

Olympic Group

Jan 1997 - Jan 1999

- Conducted business planning for the Home Décor department.
- Merchandised seasonal Christmas floor setups for 11 stores, communicating weekly updates to all locations.
- Observed sales weekly to identify replenishment needs and flag slow-selling items requiring promotional support.
- Attended trade shows for home goods to review and work with suppliers on optimal assortments and margin-gaining incentive programs.
- Collaborated with store managers to understand store-specific needs and identify areas for improvement.
- Determined advertising narratives and planned volumes for upcoming advertisements.
- Entered markdowns and maintained necessary reporting.
- Managed SKU volume of approximately 1000 with an estimated annual volume of \$5 million.

Assistant Buyer

Carrefour Egypt

On-Site

Jan 1996 - Jan 1997

- Provided clerical support to buying departments, specifically for women's apparel, coats, and cosmetics.
- Updated reporting for buyers, supporting data-driven purchasing decisions.
- Processed claims for vendors on returned merchandise.
- Visited stores and merchandised floors to improve sales opportunities based on performance reports.
- Managed SKU volume of approximately 1600 (covering women's apparel and cosmetics) with an estimated annual volume of \$7 million.

Skills

Technical Software: Adobe Creative Suite (CS5, Illustrator), Flex PLM, Microsoft Office (Excel, Word, PowerPoint)

Apparel Product Dev: Tech Pack Creation, Fit Sessions, Quality Assurance, Prototyping, Production Planning, Material Selection, Sourcing, Private Label Development, Supply Chain Optimization, Retail Merchandising

Business Management: Business Planning, Project Management, Vendor Management, Costing Analysis, Financial Reporting (OTB, Gross Margin), Sales & Marketing Strategy, Team Leadership, Process Improvement, Cross-functional Collaboration, Mentoring

Core Competencies: Organized, Detail-Oriented, Problem Solver, Creative, Collaborative, Innovative, Driven, Efficient

Interests

Snowboarding, Surfing, Yoga, Skiing, Hiking, Running, Exploring new travel areas, Finding new art